

Varma collaborates with Nagraj Manjule, a National Award-winning filmmaker on his wishlist

"He is one of my favourites and he knows it," says Varma. "When I saw *Sairat*, I wasn't able to leave the cinema for a full 15 minutes. The language wasn't familiar, yet the story hits you so hard in the gut. I haven't seen a love story so potent since." With the Amazon Prime series *Matka King*, Varma collaborates with a director on his wishlist and Manjule gets to make his long-form storytelling debut.

VIJAY VARMA PLAYS BRIJ BHATTI, WHO CHAMPIONS THE GAMBLING GAME, *MATKA*, IN THE BOMBAY OF THE 1960s, AND SEES BOTH HIS FORTUNES AND ENEMIES RISE

The show sees Varma play Brij Bhatti, who champions the gambling game, Matka, in the Bombay of the 1960s and, in the process, sees both his fortunes and the number of his enemies rise. Jumping into the world of OTT for the first time, Manjule felt the story lent itself to the format, having played the game in his village and observed that world, even if from the outside.

For Manjule, the biggest challenge lay in recreating 1960s Bombay and making audiences understand the rules of the game. "Research and writing helped us build the world. Be it clothes, establishing what's going on socially and politically and in the cotton markets and mills, we see it all," says Manjule. He also roped in a seasoned Matka player to ensure the game was being played correctly and was easy to follow. "It was like a math exam for all of us," says Manjule.

In *Matka King*, Manjule again shines a light on a character on the fringes who dares to bid for a better life. With Brij, he also gets to show how marrying ingenuity and ambition can deliver dividends, and that honesty works in business. It's what made him a fascinating character for Varma too. "We decided to make him more a businessman than a salesman. He's like an entrepreneur of that era, who motivates people and mobilises a force to do his bidding," says Varma.

—Suhani Singh

▼ **APR. 27** | *NCPA, Mumbai*

RESONANCE: SOI WINDS & PERCUSSION

The Symphony Orchestra of India's winds and percussion sections present a dynamic programme featuring Holst, Prokofiev, Márquez and Mussorgsky. Moving between grandeur and rhythmic vitality, the concert culminates in *Pictures from an Exhibition*, showcasing the ensemble's colour, precision and expressive range.



▼ **APR. 17-25** | *New Delhi, Pune, Mumbai, Bengaluru & Hyderabad*

World Jazz Festival



The sixth edition of the World Jazz Festival travels across five cities, bringing an international line-up in collaboration with the Amersfoort Jazz Festival. From New Orleans swing to Brazilian classics and tributes to African legends, it presents a cross-section of global jazz traditions and contemporary styles.

▶ **APR. 25** | *High Ultra Lounge, Bengaluru*

ONE MUSIC FESTIVAL

Set atop a rooftop venue, One Music Festival offers a curated electronic music experience featuring Romain Garcia, My Friend and leading Indian artists. Blending melodic house and techno, it unfolds as a sunset-to-late-night journey focused on atmosphere, community and immersive sound.

—Compiled by Nikhil Sardana